Project: AI-Powered Business Idea Screening and Assessment

Challenge Context

As part of Tata STRIVE's commitment to fostering sustainable livelihoods, our entrepreneurship development program supports aspiring entrepreneurs in developing their business ideas and turning them into viable livelihood opportunities.

Beneficiaries come from diverse educational, social and geographical backgrounds and may not always have access to formal business training. As a result, they may express their business ideas in the way that is most comfortable to them. Through the application, a beneficiary may write their idea in a text field, record an audio response, or upload a document such as a PDF. These submissions may also be in different Indian regional languages.

While this makes the application more accessible to beneficiaries, it creates a challenge for the assessment team. The team currently needs to go through different formats and languages, understand what the beneficiary is proposing, translate the information where required and then assess whether the idea has potential.

The assessment team also needs to understand the context around each idea. For example, whether other beneficiaries have submitted similar business ideas, or whether similar businesses are already operating in the same location. Currently, bringing all of this information together for every submission can require significant manual effort.

As the number of beneficiaries and business ideas increases, there is a need for a scalable solution that can provide the assessment team with a quick and consistent first-level understanding of every business idea.

Problem Statement

Tata STRIVE is seeking an intelligent digital solution that can act as a **first-line screening and assessment tool for beneficiary business ideas**.

The solution should be able to take business ideas submitted in different formats and languages, understand and translate them into a common format, assess their potential, and provide relevant contextual information to help the assessment team decide which ideas require deeper evaluation, mentoring, skilling, or consideration for funding opportunities.

We are looking for a solution that can:

Capture and understand business ideas from different formats: The solution should be able to process information submitted through text, audio recordings, and uploaded documents such as PDFs.

Translate and standardise the information: The solution should identify the language of the submission and translate it into English, while retaining the original submission for reference. It should then present the business idea in a simple, structured format that can be easily understood by the assessment team.

Understand the core business idea: The solution should identify key elements of the proposal, such as what the business is, what product or service is being offered, who the intended customers are, what problem is being addressed, where the business will operate, and any information provided about investment or revenue.

Assess and rate the business idea: The solution should provide an initial assessment of the idea based on parameters such as clarity, customer need, market potential, feasibility, competition, differentiation, and completeness of information. It should highlight the strengths of the idea as well as gaps, risks, or information that needs further validation.

Identify similar business ideas: The solution should compare submissions across beneficiaries and identify cases where multiple beneficiaries have proposed similar or related business ideas. This can help the assessment team identify potential overlaps and understand patterns across submissions.

Provide location-based business insights: Where location information is available, the solution should help identify whether similar businesses or services are already operating in the same or nearby location. This can provide the assessment team with an initial understanding of the local competitive environment.

Provide a consolidated assessment for the team: The solution should bring these insights together into a simple assessment view for each beneficiary, showing the translated business idea, initial rating, strengths, gaps, similar ideas, location-based insights and areas that may require further assessment.

The solution should generate:

- **Domain-wise rating** – rating of the business idea across defined assessment domains.
- **Trade-wise rating** – rating and comparison of business ideas within the same trade.
- **Cohort-wise rating** – comparison of business idea ratings within the same cohort.
- **Across-cohort comparison** – comparison of business idea ratings across different cohorts to identify trends and patterns.

Impact of the Solution

This solution would help Tata STRIVE make the initial assessment of business ideas faster, more consistent, and more scalable, while ensuring that beneficiaries are not disadvantaged because of the language or format in which they express their ideas.

For our Beneficiaries (The entrepreneurs): Beneficiaries would be able to share their business ideas in a format and language that is comfortable for them. Their ideas can then be translated, structured, and assessed without requiring them to first understand formal business-plan formats. The identified gaps can also help them understand what they need to strengthen before moving forward.

For our Assessment Team: The solution would reduce the manual effort involved in reading different formats, translating submissions, understanding unstructured ideas, and comparing multiple business proposals. Instead, the team would receive a structured first-level assessment and can spend more time on deeper evaluation and mentoring of the ideas that require human intervention.

For Tata STRIVE (Operational efficiency): The solution would enable Tata STRIVE to screen and assess a larger number of business ideas across its programs and locations. By combining business idea assessment with similarity and location-based insights, Tata STRIVE can build a stronger understanding of the entrepreneurship opportunities emerging from its programs and make better-informed decisions around mentoring, skilling, and potential funding.

Key Considerations

a) Solution should support multiple Indian regional languages and different submission formats such as text, audio and PDF/document uploads.

b) Solution should work preferably in real time

c) Assessment should provide clear reasoning and identify the factors contributing to the rating rather than providing only a score.

d) Original beneficiary submissions should be retained alongside translated and AI-generated outputs for reference and validation.

e) Location-based insights and identification of similar businesses should use reliable and available data sources.

f) Use open-source LLM models or optimal and scalable models.